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Original Article

Professional Practice and Teacher Quality: Insights from Nairobi County's Public Secondary Schools, Kenya

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Keywords:

TPAD (Teacher Performance Appraisal and Development), Professional practice, Teacher quality.

TPAD (Teacher Performance Appraisal and Development) is an essential instrument in guiding school and classroom management practices for quality and relevant education for all. It also enables teachers to respond to global shifts professionally and to diverse learners' needs through structured evaluation. However, teachers' know-how, accountability, and job experience hinder an effective appraisal process. Thus, aggravates the gap between policy expectations and teachers' intentions in the implementation of this policy framework in traditional educational environments. This also adds to inefficiencies of the appraisal process for teachers. Against this background, the study determined the level of influence of professional practice on teacher quality in public secondary schools in Nairobi County, Kenya, and identified innovative ways that may enhance its use in education. The study was guided by the following objective: to determine the extent to which professional practice influences teacher quality in public secondary schools in Nairobi County, Kenya. The theory of professional capital guided the study. An embedded design was used for the study. The study's target population was 115 principals, 3146 teachers and 11 Teachers Service Commission (TSC) Sub-County Directors. A stratified random sampling method was used to sample 92 principals from different categories of schools, 346 teachers and 11 TSC Sub-County Directors. The findings showed that teacher quality was determined by professional practice. Internet access, workload and seeing the TPAD tool as a mere compliance exercise and not a growth tool were among the issues reported. The study recommended that specific measures ought to be enacted, such as provision of allowances for teachers and time to be able to attend professional development workshops. Also, increase training, sensitisation, mentorship and follow-ups through bodies like the Teachers Service Commission (TSC) to improve the way teachers engage and use appraisal tools.

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INTRODUCTION

Background to the Study

Worldwide, schools have developed a range of reforms intended to enhance the quality of education provided to learners. One such reform is teachers' performance appraisal (Awiten et al., 2025). It denotes a systematic, ongoing process for assessing teachers' professional practices, competencies, and effectiveness in achieving educational goals. The process entails comparing performance with predetermined standards and delivering constructive feedback to support professional development, accountability, and higher instructional quality (OECD, 2021; TSC, 2023). It also includes collecting, analysing, and reporting performance data, which may inform decisions regarding tenure, promotions, motivation, staff discipline, and overall deployment. Thereby contributing to the realisation of international frameworks such as Sustainable Development Goal 4, which seeks to ensure quality education and relevant knowledge and skills for all (Education 2030, 2016). Different countries use terms such as performance management, teacher development, and professional standards interchangeably. For consistency, this study used TPAD to encompass all of them.

In this sense, TPAD has a long-standing international history. It originated in France in the 1970s. It was introduced within reforms designed to enhance state-owned enterprises. These reforms mandated that public-sector employees achieve specified, predetermined targets (OECD, 2019). As a result, it has been cascaded into education. School leaders are mandated to

conduct appraisals focused on competences, development, and feedback. Often, for career development, including possible connections to salary changes or career advancement (Kostas et al., 2020).

Similarly, in the United States, the rollout of appraisal programmes has accelerated growing pressure on educational institutions to demonstrate results with their learners. As a result, teachers' appraisal has become common practice as a means of raising instructional performance (Christie & Lingard, 2020).

In Singapore, performance appraisal of teachers is assessed through a competency-based evaluation system called the Enhanced Performance Management System (EPMS), designed to promote teaching excellence (Steiner, 2020). This approach has helped position Singapore's education system among the best in the world (Lee and Tan, 2022). This achievement rests on several factors: ensuring the system effectively delivers essential instruction to learners; recruiting the right individuals into teaching; and supporting their growth into skilled teachers. Further, EPMS assesses 16 competencies spanning both classroom instruction and broader involvement in school life (Hairon & Loh, 2022).

In Japan, the introduction of teachers' appraisal systems is seen as a means of improving teaching practice and guiding professional growth (Kagami et al., 2023). It is designed to foster skill development through a two-way process that combines self-assessment with formal performance reviews, ultimately producing individualised guidance and feedback from school leaders (Shaodong et al., 2023).

In the African context, for instance, in Egypt, teacher professional growth relies on appraisals to identify training needs and encourage development. However, heavy managerial workloads leave head teachers with little time to adequately evaluate teachers. As a result, teachers receive only superficial feedback and minimal guidance for their professional development, which ultimately lowers their performance and undermines the quality of education (Marey & Hesham, 2020). Similarly, in Botswana, the implementation appraisal process has produced mixed teacher perceptions of effectiveness and meaning. The system ties performance to pay and promotion (Bester & Hofisi, 2020). The teachers often view the performance appraisals that school administrators conduct as oppressive and punitive, which produces significant negative emotions among them (Seoleseng, 2019; Kgosiemang & Khoza, 2022).

In Ethiopia, teacher performance appraisal aims to increase teachers' motivation, encourage professional development, and raise the quality of education. The system sets up professional standards, implements performance contracts for teachers, and uses multiple sources of data for evaluation. However, the system's complicated structure and ambiguous criteria have made it ineffective in motivating teachers and enhancing their performance (Mirado, 2019). Because of this, teachers and school leaders are free of training in results-based appraisal. The system remained routine instead of enhancing teaching quality and education (Sayeeduddin & Vijayakumar, 2018).

In the Kenyan context, the Teachers Service Commission (TSC) introduced the TPAD system in 2016 to account for teachers' professionalism and accountability. Regulation 52 (1) of the TSC Code of Regulations for Teachers assigned the TSC the main task of monitoring teachers' activities and ensuring that they follow the educational system's objectives when it created TPAD (TSC, 2015). The TSC intended TPAD to oversee and continuously evaluate teachers' performance in order to maintain teaching

standards at the institutional level. Some of the TPAD's specific objectives are to provide public school learners with excellent teaching; to offer teachers avenues for skills enhancement; to identify performance gaps in teachers and provide them with professional development support; to ensure that teacher appraisal is fair, efficient, and reliable; and, lastly, to safeguard students' rights and safety (Tumusiime et al., 2021).

Under the TPAD mechanism, teachers are designated as "appraisees," while colleagues such as heads of departments, deputy principals, or principals serve as "appraisers" responsible for evaluating performance and offering feedback (Owiye et al., 2020). The appraisal begins with a formal meeting to set yearly goals. By and large, emphasising the appraisee's skills while also considering the appraiser's needs. Throughout the year, the appraiser observes the appraisee's work, supports them, provides motivation and frequent feedback, and collaboratively solves any arising problems. If organisational priorities shift, the appraiser adjusts the original objectives. At the end of the review period, the appraiser evaluates the appraisee's performance across different areas using predetermined criteria and assigns a rating. Finally, both parties meet to review performance outcomes, discuss the ratings, and reach a mutual understanding of how they were determined (Wanjiku et al., 2024).

The TSC TPAD Evaluation Report (2016-2019) showed that, among the 87.37% of teachers in the five identified constituencies, 87.37% achieved their set goals (TSC, 2021a). About 84% of respondents attended appraisal meetings, while 78.2% identified development needs. This indicates that 16% of teachers skipped the sessions and 21.8% overlooked gaps in their self-assessments, exposing flaws in the appraisal process (Masika, 2022). Other gaps include rating biases. Appraisers may commit strictness or leniency errors. By consistently scoring teachers too low or too high. These flaws make TPAD prone to error and may lead to unfair teacher appraisals (Tuytens et al., 2020).

Another contributor is limited ICT skills among appraisers, causing potential errors in the appraisal process. Some hire ICT technicians to conduct appraisals. But reliance on external support sometimes excludes essential participants, thus raising concerns about appraisal quality. Teachers' fear of technological change and disruptive innovations like artificial intelligence (AI), combined with heavy school and classroom workloads, intensifies the problem (Thai et al., 2022).

Teacher quality rises with competence. Embodying mastery of subject matter, pedagogy, and professionalism (Barrera-Pedemonte, 2016). More experienced teachers produce better outcomes, especially in school and classroom management and in differentiating instruction, than less experienced colleagues. Teachers with three to five years of experience usually outperform newly hired ones. These advantages fade when experienced teachers skip ongoing professional growth and reflection. Seasoned teachers adapt lessons to diverse learning styles and apply recommended strategies more readily (Gershenson et al., 2021).

In Nairobi County, the TPAD system reflects unique features shaped by diverse school contexts, unequal resources, and large teacher numbers. As Kenya's capital and education hub, Nairobi's public secondary schools face heightened pressure for accountability and instructional quality. Although TPAD aims to boost teacher performance and professional development, its actual impact on teacher quality in this urban setting remains unclear (Ministry of Education, 2020).

Statement of the Problem

Despite the fact that TPAD promotes quality education by holding teachers accountable, several issues, including limited teacher professional practices, expose teachers to significant rating biases, undermining the accuracy and fairness of evaluations. It widens the gap between policy expectations and classroom

realities, fuelling inefficiencies in the appraisal framework. It is further worsened by teachers' low motivation to adopt digital tools and heavy school workloads. These factors reduce teaching effectiveness, efficiency, and overall school management.

Purpose of the Study

To determine the level of influence of professional practice on teacher quality in public secondary schools in Nairobi County, Kenya, and identify innovative ways that may enhance its use in education.

Study Objectives

To determine the extent to which professional practice influences teacher quality in public secondary schools in Nairobi County, Kenya.

Null Hypothesis

H₀₁: Professional practice does not significantly influence teacher quality in Nairobi County's public secondary schools.

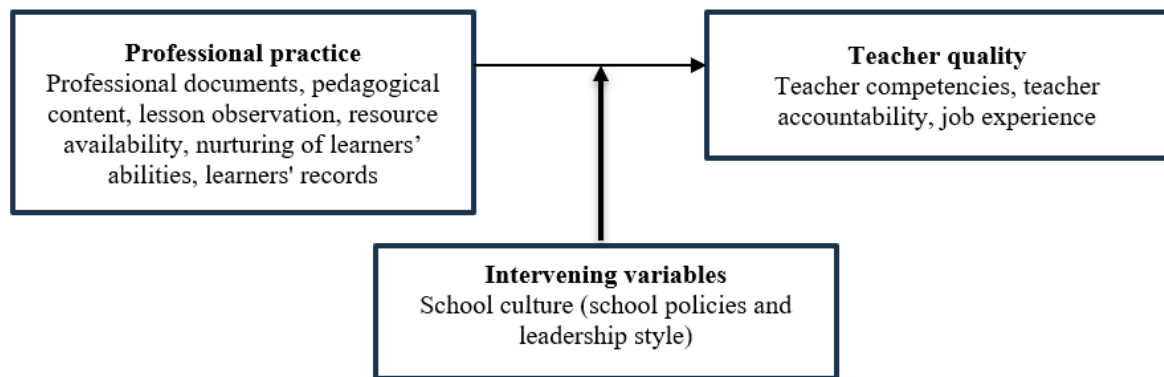
Theoretical Framework

This study applied Hargreaves and Fullan's Professional Capital Theory (2012) because it emphasises that teachers as professionals excel through three forms of capital: human capital (individual skills and knowledge), social capital (collaborative trust within the school), and decisional capital (informed, independent decision-making). This framework shows that high teacher quality drives continuous professional development, fosters a principal-led supportive environment built on trust and cooperation, and empowers teachers to collectively solve problems and make instructional decisions that improve student outcomes (Melesse & Belay, 2022). The theory treats teaching as a knowledge-intensive profession, where quality depends on teachers' accumulated knowledge and skills from formal education, pedagogical expertise, and contextual

understanding (Belay, Melese & Seifu, 2022). Accordingly, the study established the extent to which professional practice influenced teacher

quality. Figure 1 shows the conceptual framework.

Figure 1: Conceptual Framework on the Influence of Professional Practice on Teacher Quality



REVIEW OF THE LITERATURE REVIEW

Pharis et al. (2019) examined how rural Kentucky high school teachers and administrators viewed TPGES, its impact on their grasp of evaluation, and the call for more professional development after year one. The study revealed varied views among participants on the value of further training and their grasp of TPGES. Furthermore, four implications for professional development were found by the researchers from the professional development activities of participating educators in TPGES. The study used qualitative data, thus showing a methodological gap. The current study adopted both qualitative and quantitative methods.

Hajovsky et al. (2020) examined links between teacher–student relationship quality and math achievement, showing teacher self-efficacy mediated the effect in a NICHD sample of 881 children. According to their research, teachers' perceptions of their own efficacy were somewhat to strongly boosted when they had a strong sense of connection to their students. The present study used an embedded design to establish the extent to which teacher-student and resource-student ratios influenced teacher quality.

A study by Mbabu et al. (2022) on teacher performance assessment and its returns to

education used David McClelland's Learned Need Theory of motivation and employed a mixed-method design. The findings revealed that over 75% of respondents believed TPAD helps identify teacher performance gaps and supports professional development. Additionally, over 85% of teachers praised high-performing students, and over 85.2% agreed that setting goals through TPAD improved time management aligned with lesson objectives. On the whole, TPAD has a major positive impact on teachers' motivation and has a considerable effect on students' performance. The research emphasised the effect of TPAD on teaching, but only indirectly hinted at its effect on teacher quality, which was the main point of the investigation.

Nugroho (2024) conducted a review of the literature to find out how teacher performance is related to their experience and training. The findings show that experience makes teachers adaptable, sharpens problem-solving, and boosts classroom engagement, while continuous training updates methods and encourages the use of technology. The study concluded that upholding high teaching standards and raising student achievement require an organised approach to teacher development that blends training programmes with real-world experience. The study also emphasised the value of practical

experience in raising teaching efficacy. However, this study relied solely on secondary data to draw its conclusions. Building on these insights, this research utilised the primary data that was collected from both teachers and school administrators of public secondary schools to assess the extent to which teacher quality would be influenced by teachers' adherence to the recommended use of pedagogical content, stipulated in the TPAD policy.

Pozas et al. (2024) studied German pre-service teacher profiles and their possible use of ICT. The research involved a sample of 155 pre-service teachers and found no significant relationships between teacher profiles, age, teaching programmes, or gender. Similarly, research by El Ouazzani Chahdi et al. (2024) on the effective integration of ICT in the flipped classroom demonstrated that the flipped classroom model outperforms traditional methods, particularly due to its use of personalised instructional videos. The studies stressed that teachers must adjust instruction to fit each student's individual needs. This research, based on these precepts, might set the standard of professional practice for locating, getting, and applying technology in teaching and learning.

Cheng et al. (2024) applied structural equation modelling in China to identify key factors shaping teacher quality and competence, using 32 items. The findings revealed that teachers' motivation to participate was central to effective training and improved competence. The results also showed that teachers' intrinsic motivation to engage had a significant positive influence on both the "effectiveness of training methods" and the "augmentation of double qualified teacher competence," while the "effectiveness of training methods," as an extrinsic factor, showed a significant positive impact on the "augmentation of double qualified teacher competence." Considering explicit variables, the research pointed out that the improvement of teachers' pedagogical skills and the development of students have the strongest impact on the motivation to participate, while theoretical and

practical training together with professional competition have a more significant effect on the training results. Building on this understanding, this study employed statistical methods such as correlation to determine the degree to which teachers' deliberate use of professional documents in their instruction influences the calibre of their work.

Erikawati's (2024) study reviewed articles to investigate how peer observations can enhance teachers' professional quality. The results demonstrated that peer observations improved teachers' professional quality. Teachers' peers also offered helpful criticism and social support. The study's conclusion emphasised the value of cooperation and support among school personnel for the professional development of teachers. According to the study, it is necessary to create observation systems that are focused on ongoing education and enhancing teachers' professionalism in all aspects. As a result, this study established how much a self-professional support plan influences the quality of teachers.

Mang'uui et al. (2021) examined how resource access influenced teacher performance in Kitui, sampling 40 principals and 488 secondary teachers through purposive and random methods. Data came from questionnaires and document reviews, but results showed no significant link between resources and performance ($p = 0.001 < 0.05$). The research called for the provision of sufficient teaching and learning materials, managers making sure that teachers have a balanced workload, and, along with that, encouraging collaborative engagement with teachers to secure the supply of instructional materials, which should also include electronic resources for both teachers and students. Starting from resource shortages, this study examined how teachers intentionally and creatively use what was available to improve the quality.

In another study, Graham et al. (2020) examined the correlations between teachers' tenure and the calibre of instruction. The study found no clear evidence of weaker instruction among teachers

with 0-3 years' experience, though some decline appeared at 4 - 5 years. Results suggested overall teaching quality improves with targeted support and evidence-based development. While testing claims of novice teachers' lower competence, the study assessed how experience with TPAD principles influenced instructional quality.

Chen et al. (2023) surveyed teachers online from 896 schools to explore their challenges in identifying and nurturing students gifted and differently abled. The results revealed that upgrading the awareness and knowledge of general teachers made them better at identifying students who require support in the development of their talents. Consequently, the research advised that administrations ought to establish an efficient support system comprising human resources and monetary provisions to not only close the gaps in opportunities but also respond to the demands of teachers. Consequently, the current research substantiated the effect of teachers' awareness of the talent development of learners as a factor influencing the quality of the school and classroom environment.

An action research study by Strauss (2024) in Namibia focused on teachers' skills in the assessment of learners' reading abilities and the provision of appropriately targeted interventions to enhance their results. The study relied on data from artefacts collected during the training and teacher reflections in focus group discussions. The findings highlighted not only teachers' accuracy in recording running records but also the influence of reading speed, fluency, and text comprehension on learners' assessment as well as their overall reading proficiency levels.

Focus groups highlighted the need for better assessment tools, attention to language diversity,

ways to offset class size effects, and more teacher training. They also urged teachers to apply linguistic frameworks to strengthen literacy assessment skills. By addressing the shortage of language frameworks in the curriculum, this research is a step toward evaluating the degree to which teacher proficiency in recording learner data impacts the quality of the educational experience at the school and classroom levels.

METHODOLOGY

The study used an embedded mixed-methods design to analyse quantitative and qualitative data concurrently. It prioritised quantitative data, using qualitative insights to deepen understanding (Orodho et al., 2016). This approach balanced biases and limitations inherent in single-method studies (Tambwe, 2017). The quantitative strand employed questionnaires, while the qualitative component used an interview schedule.

The study population comprised 115 principals, 3146 teachers, and 11 TSC Sub-County Directors (TSC Regional Director, 2025). Using Krejcie and Morgan's (1970) table, the researcher applied stratified random sampling to select 237 teachers and 73 principals for the study. Kombo and Tromp (2006) note that stratified random sampling ensures representation from distinct subgroups within the broader population. Malterud (2016) indicates that qualitative studies usually require a sample size of 5 to 50 participants. Therefore, the researcher used stratified random sampling to select 11 TSC Sub-County Directors and 73 principals. The stratified random sampling method was used to select 92 principals from different categories of schools, 346 teachers, and 11 TSC Sub-County Directors. Table 1 provides the summary.

Table 1: Sampling Frame

	N	Sampling Technique	n
TSC Sub-County Directors	11	Stratified	11
Principals	115	Stratified	73
Teachers	3146	Stratified	237

FINDINGS

Table 2 kicks off with an overview of the instruments' return rate.

Instruments' Return Rate

Table 2: Instrument Return Rate

Respondents	Admitted	Returned	Return Rate
Principals	92	73	79.34%
Teachers	346	237	68.50%
Total	438	310	70.77%

Table 2 shows that teachers returned questionnaires at a lower rate (68.50%, or 237 out of 346) than principals did (79.34%, or 73 out of 92). Researchers attribute the 10.84 percentage point difference to the self-administration of the tools and to respondents' willingness to participate in the study. Overall, respondents

returned 310 out of 438 questionnaires, yielding a combined return rate of 70.77%. The first segment of the questionnaire sought to establish respondents' biodata, and Table 3 provides their demographic details.

Biodata of the Respondents

Table 3: Demographic Information

		Principals	Teachers
Gender	Males	26 (36.62 %)	84 (35.9%)
	Females	45 (63.38%)	150 (64.1%)
	Total	71	235
Age	30 years and below	0%	42 (17.87%)
	31 to 39 years	0%	104 (44.26%)
	40 to 49 years	18 (24.66%)	40 (17.02%)
	50 years and above	55 (75.34%)	49 (20.85%)
	Total	73	235
Years of experience	5 years and below	10 (13.89%)	82 (35.19%)
	6 to 10 years	19 (26.39%)	57 (24.46%)
	11 to 15 years	9 (12.50%)	31 (13.30%)
	16 years and above	34 (47.22%)	63 (27.04%)
	Total	72	233
Highest level of academic qualification	Diploma	0%	13 (5.49%)
	Degree	52 (71.23%)	180 (75.95%)
	Master's	21 (28.77%)	44 (18.57%)
	PhD	0%	0%
	Total	73	237
Category of the school	Sub-County	29 (42.65%)	100 (43.86%)
	County	11 (16.18%)	35 (15.35%)
	Extra County	19 (27.94%)	57 (25.00%)
	National	19 (27.94%)	27 (11.84%)
	special school	0%	9 (3.95%)

Table 3 captures the respondents' profiles across gender, age, teaching experience, academic qualifications, and school categories. From the gender perspective, the findings showed that more teaching staff (N = 235) than school leaders (71) participated in this inquiry. In both groups, females formed the majority (principals: N = 45,

P = 63.38%; and teachers: N = 150, P = 64.1%) compared to males (principals: N = 26, P = 36.62%; and teachers: N = 84, P = 35.9%). A significantly larger proportion of principals (N = 55, P = 75.34%) were aged 50 years and above, while 24.66% (N = 18) fell between 40 and 49 years, compared to only 20.85% (N = 49) of

teachers in that older bracket. Principals also reported far more extensive experience: 47.22% (N = 34) had served for 16 years or more, compared to 27.04% (N = 63) of teachers. Academically, the majority of respondents in both roles held degrees, though a higher percentage of principals (N = 21, P = 28.77%) held a master's qualification than teachers (N = 44, P = 18.57%). Principals worked predominantly in sub-county, extra-county, and national schools, whereas teachers included a small number (N = 9, P = 3.95%) working in special schools.

The study's objective sought to uncover the extent to which professional practice influenced teacher quality in public secondary schools in Nairobi County. To realise this objective, the researcher asked teachers in different categories of public secondary schools to rate the extent to which they felt their professional practice influenced their quality. The researcher used a four-point Likert scale, anchoring the responses on the following conditions: a value of 1 indicated strong disagreement, 2 indicated disagreement, 3 indicated agreement, and 4 indicated strong agreement. Table 4 presents the summary.

Influences of Professional Practice on Teacher Quality

Table 4: Teachers' Responses on the Extent of Agreement on Professional Practice

statement		SD	D	A	SA		mean
I develop schemes of work, lesson plans, and records that are aligned with the syllabus and curriculum	N	4	1	62	167	234	3.68
	P	1.71%	0.43%	26.50%	71.37%	100%	
I use my subject mastery and a variety of teaching methods to create clear and engaging learning experiences	N	3	1	48	182	234	3.75
	P	1.28%	0.43%	20.51 %	77.78 %	100%	
I conduct termly lesson observations to identify professional gaps and evaluate teaching methods	N	4	2	69	158	233	3.64
	P	1.72 %	0.86 %	29.61 %	67.81 %	100%	
I utilise both improvised and procured teaching and learning resources	N	1	7	115	105	228	3.42
	P	0.44 %	3.07 %	50.44%	46.05 %	100%	
I use academic records and Individualised Education Plans (IEPs) to assess student abilities and tailor instruction to their learning preferences	N	4	27	116	83	230	3.21
	P	1.74%	11.74 %	50.43%	36.09 %	100%	
I identify and cultivate student talent	N	1	13	104	112	230	3.42
	P	0.43 %	5.65 %	45.22%	48.70%	100%	
I integrate digital resources and ICT into teaching and learning	N	2	13	115	95	225	3.35
	p	0.89 %	5.78 %	51.11 %	42.22%	100%	
I analyse students' progress, provide timely feedback, and implement targeted	N	3	4	73	152	232	3.61
	P	1.29%	1.72 %	31.47%	65.52 %	100%	
average							3.51

Overall, the findings in Table 4 showed that a significant majority of teachers in different public secondary school categories strongly agreed that they routinely exercised their professional practice while discharging their classroom and school duties. The overall mean of 3.51, which falls between "agree" and "strongly agree," substantiates these assertions. By and large, over 70 per cent of teachers (77.78%) also expressed the strongest consensus regarding their pedagogical effectiveness, particularly in using varied teaching methods, as the mean of 3.75 indicates. They also showed strong consensus in aligning lesson plans with the curriculum (71.37%), as the mean of 3.68 indicates. In support of these descriptive statistics, one of the principals remarked that:

Lesson observation under TPAD enables supervisors to assess instructional delivery, learner engagement, classroom management and use of teaching and learning resources. Teachers who consistently prepare professional documents tend to demonstrate better organisation, effective pedagogy, resulting in improved learning outcomes. (Principal 13)

Besides, over 60 per cent of teachers strongly agreed (67.81%) that they conducted termly lesson observations to identify professional gaps and evaluated teaching methods, with a mean of 3.64 indicating this. These results echoed the sentiments of one of the principals that professionalism “enhances objective content delivery, evaluation and feedback” (Principal 14). Another principal mentioned that professional practice,

It includes preparation of professional documents like schemes of work and lesson plans, lesson observation, and use of teaching and learning resources. When teachers plan well, use appropriate resources, and reflect on their teaching, the quality of instruction improves, and learners perform better. (Principal 17).

More than 50 per cent of teachers (50.43%) agreed that they kept academic records and personalised education plans (IEPs) to help tailor their instruction. This item received the lowest rating score, placing it in the "agree" category, with a mean of 3.21. Similarly, over 50 per cent of teachers (50.44%) believed that they used both improvised and procured resources while teaching, as indicated by a mean of 3.42. Over 40 per cent of teachers (48.70%) either agreed or strongly agreed that they cultivated student talent, as indicated by a mean of 3.42. These results align with the opinion of one principal, who stated that "a teacher who bears all the necessary professional documents is bound to be organised and deliver the content adequately to learners, thereby making sure that all learners grasp the intended content" (Principal 15).

More than 50 per cent of respondents (51.11%) agreed that they integrated digital resources and ICT into teaching and learning, as the mean of 3.35 demonstrated, corresponding to "agree" on the Likert scale. Lastly, more than 60 per cent of teachers (65.52%) strongly agreed that they analysed students' progress, provided timely feedback, and implemented targeted interventions, as the mean of 3.61 substantiated. These statistics align with the sentiment of one principal, who stated that.

Teacher preparedness, as evidenced by the quality of professional documents and learning and teaching resources prepared by a teacher, is a key indicator of TPAD influencing quality of instruction. A well-prepared teacher is more productive, and therefore the teaching and learning process is efficient. (Principal 18).

These statistical analyses substantiate a fundamental principle: teachers' professional quality determines their core pedagogical skills and content knowledge. Supporting this, one of the sub-county directors of education stated that "teachers who consistently prepare professional documents tend to demonstrate better organisation, effective pedagogy, resulting in

improved learning outcomes" (TSC SCD 05). These findings support the desktop review by Nugroho (2024), who found that experience makes teachers more adaptable, sharpens their problem-solving techniques, and boosts their classroom engagement. They also align with the findings of Chen et al. (2023) and Erikawati (2024), who found that peer observations not only improved teachers' professional quality but also offered helpful criticism and social support, helping teachers identify learners who required support in developing their talents. Similarly, the findings align with those of Cheng et al. (2024) in China, who established that intrinsic motivation drove teachers to go out of their way in teaching, which significantly and positively influenced their pedagogical skills and revealed their competence.

The findings further showed a wide range of perspectives concerning the level of utilisation of teaching and learning resources. Suggesting that, while teachers saw these as important aspects of their quality, they viewed them as slightly less critical than their primary instructional and planning duties. These insights could be attributed to diverse resource gaps that teachers might be experiencing in different school categories. What is filled or indicated in the TPD tool might not necessarily be reflected in what is on the ground in different categories of schools in Nairobi County. To substantiate these claims, one of the TSC SCD clarified that TPAD "guides on timelines and the needed resources one has to equip oneself with for better content delivery" (TSC SCD 04). Also, one of the principals alluded that "our teachers attend workshops when called upon and exercise professionalism when delivering their lessons, managing classes assigned. When there is a challenge, we convene a meeting and address it in an amicable way. This, for me, demonstrates their quality" (Principal 09). These excerpts from TSC SCD and the principal further clarify that regardless of scarce instructional resources, standards set out in the TPAD framework are intended to serve as a benchmark to not only enhance teachers' quality but also what teachers must aspire to. These quantitative and qualitative outcomes agree with

the findings of Graham et al. (2020), who found that overall teacher quality improved with targeted support and evidence-based development. On the other hand, the findings disagreed with the outcome of Mang'uui et al. (2021), who found an insignificant relationship between resources and performance at the 0.05 level of significance.

The findings reflect a positive perception of ICT integration in instructional practices by teachers. In other words, teachers' views on ICT integration appeared relatively similar across the sampled groups. The findings disagreed with the findings of Pozas et al. (2024) in Germany, who found no significant relationships between teachers' profiles and teaching programmes. But agreed with the findings of El Ouazzani Chahdi et al. (2024), who found that the flipped classroom model outperformed traditional methods, particularly due to its use of personalised instructional videos.

The findings indicated a strong positive tendency toward teaching practice and suggest that the majority of teachers believe they were actively monitoring student progress and providing feedback to enhance learning outcomes. The findings are in agreement with the output of Strauss (2024) in Namibia, who found that not only did teachers observe accuracy in recording running records but also influenced reading speed, fluency, and text comprehension on learners' assessments as well as their overall reading proficiency levels.

Apart from the descriptive statistics discussed, Pearson's product-moment correlation was used to test the null hypothesis, H_{01} , as to whether there was no statistically significant influence of professional practice on teacher quality in public secondary schools in Nairobi County. The choice of this statistical method was inspired by professional capital theory's emphasis that human expertise has a tremendous impact on the teaching profession. They empower teachers' knowledge, skills, and decision-making abilities, which, in turn, increase teacher quality (Melesse & Belay,

2022). Responses from teachers were used because they were the implementers of the TPAD tool.

Before Pearson product-moment correlation was calculated, assumptions were first reviewed for valid interpretation. The first assumption, as Stockemer (2019) states, is that the variables should be continuous. This requirement was met as data were collected using a four-point Likert scale with 1 indicating “strongly disagree”, 2 “disagree”, 3 “agree” and 4 “strongly agree”.

Four-point Likert scale items were averaged to yield new continuous variables. The second assumption was met, which is that each pair of observations ought to be independent of the others, meaning that the data from one construct should not influence those from another (Stockemer 2019). Lastly, the distribution should not be skewed. Therefore, a normality test was done, and both the Kolmogorov-Smirnov and Shapiro-Wilk test results were insignificant ($p > 0.05$). The outcomes are summarised in Table 5.

Table 5: Pearson Product-Moment Correlation Between Professional Practice and Teacher Quality

	Professional practice
Teacher quality	0.58*
*<0.05	

Pearson product-moment correlation results in Table 5 demonstrated that professional practice and teacher quality had a positive and significant moderate correlation at the 0.05 level of confidence. This is substantiated by a correlation coefficient of 0.58, indicating a large effect size. These findings suggested that when teachers intentionally observe professional practice, it consequently increases their quality. The null hypothesis was rejected, and the alternative hypothesis was adopted that there was a statistically significant influence of professional practice on teacher quality in public secondary schools in Nairobi County. These inferential statistics tally with the sentiment of one of the principals that “TPAD also guides the teacher on the preparation of the professional document, carrying out of lesson observation and preparation of teaching resources” (Principal 09. Another principal had this to say:

TPAD offers teachers a professional opportunity for self-review and assessment in regard to their termly and annual goals. Through TPAD, teachers are able to identify talents and nurture them from an early age, and this is a key indicator of teachers' quality (Principal 45).

These outcomes agree with the outcomes of Hajovsky et al. (2020), who found that teachers' perceptions of their own efficacy had a strong association with their professional practice. The outcomes also resonated with professional capital theory, which emphasises that integrating human expertise in teaching significantly influences the teaching profession. It enhances teachers' skills and decision-making, ultimately improving educational quality (Cole & Duffy, 2024).

Summary of the Findings

Key findings showed that a significant majority of teachers deliberately practised their profession in an expected way, including aligning lesson plans and professional documents with the curriculum, using varied teaching methods, and conducting lesson observations. It was also reported that 29.46% felt the appraisal process was too engaging (time-consuming), and 11.63% described it as tiresome, leading some to treat it as a mere compliance exercise rather than a growth tool. Approximately 10% of teachers expressed concerns over mismatched ratings or bias in the evaluation process. Again, teachers who consistently demonstrated professional practice were more likely to improve their quality, as

indicated by a positive and moderate correlation of 0.58, with a large effect size.

CONCLUSIONS

Professional practice significantly influenced teacher quality, as research rejected the null hypothesis for professional practice. Despite these benefits, the effectiveness of the appraisal process was hampered by infrastructural gaps. For instance, inadequate internet access, as well as heavy workloads and digital illiteracy among teachers. Consequently, while TPAD successfully promotes accountability and pedagogical alignment, the findings showed that it ought to be supported by continuous ICT training and institutional mentorship to ensure it is embraced as a growth tool rather than a mere compliance exercise.

Recommendations

The study recommends that the government should provide allowances for teachers to attend professional development, both physical and online, using online platforms. The government should increase training, sensitisation, and mentorship from bodies like the Teachers Service Commission (TSC) to improve how teachers engage with and use appraisal tools.

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